variations on a theme, different individual developments of it. To follow with a conceptual thread running through this volume, Russia, like the other BRICS, acts as a transmission belt of global capitalism. At the same time, the many differences between BRICS sustain and help intensify a logic of competition between them, and also potentially intensify points of pressure and friction with the West. What this points to is that inter-imperialist rivalries are inter-capitalist rivalries, all arising from the same global system. These rivalries, therefore, occur not across geo-temporal boundaries separating the old geopolitics from the new, the territorial expansionism from the cosmopolitanism – but across the lines drawn by overlapping state–class interests. And in this process, national states still play a central role in articulating such rivalries. The specificity of Russia, then, both in terms of its relations with the other BRICS and of its current opposition to the West in Ukraine, is that it shows, more clearly than any other case, that geopolitical fractures in the system are as integral to contemporary capitalism as its globalising tendencies; the open conflict in the Donbass area of the Ukraine is no mere 'flashpoint' but a determinant crisis with an unclear resolution. Globalising tendencies of their own cannot undo the potential for interstate competition on a large scale. In such conditions, movements of opposition from below in the BRICS might not only offer an essential stepping stone for a renewal and reinvigoration of the global left but, critically, represent a most necessary platform against the dangers of imperialist barbarism.

Notes

1. The precise composition of the ruling elite, and their character is a hotly debated point in the literature. I have only provided broad strokes here drawing on previous work, but for an essential starting point see Kryshtanovskaya and White 2003, 2005a and 2005b; and critical interventions in Rivera and Rivera 2006 and Wood 2007. Once again, the most recent forensic report (but one which elides a full notion of class) is Karen Dawisha's excellent, if controversial, *Putin's Kleptocracy* (2014).
2. Naturally, the official position of the Russian Federation is that it does not have troops in Ukraine, though the annexation of Crimea and the violence in the Donbass would surely increase the overall figure by several thousands.

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